Honestly, it started with cartoons.

Growing up in Nigeria, I spent many Saturday mornings watching Japanese anime — Naruto, Dragon Ball, and others. I didn't think much of it at the time; it was just good television. But looking back, those shows were my first real window into a completely different world — one shaped by discipline, loyalty, and the belief that effort and character matter more than anything else. Those values stayed with me long before I ever seriously considered Japan as a place I could actually go.

As I got older and began learning more about Japan beyond the cartoons, I became genuinely fascinated — not just by the culture or the food, but by the way Japanese society is structured: the respect for others, the attention to detail in everyday life, and the way communities function. There is something about Japan that I find deeply compelling. It is different, yes, but not in a way that feels foreign — more like something I already understand but have not yet experienced.

The other honest reason is this: I want to grow. Living and working in Japan, teaching in schools, and navigating a new language and culture is not the comfortable option. But I have never learned much from comfort. I want to be in a place that challenges me to become more patient, more observant, and more intentional. Japan feels like exactly that kind of environment.

I also believe I have something meaningful to offer in return. Nigeria is one of the most diverse countries in the world — with many languages, religions, and perspectives coexisting. I have grown up learning how to communicate across differences, how to find common ground, and how to make people feel at ease even in unfamiliar situations. I would bring all of that into the classroom and into any community I become part of.

I am not coming to Japan for a gap year or just a story to tell. I am coming because I have been curious about this place for most of my life, and I am finally in a position to act on that curiosity.